Student Guide: NotebookLM Business Analysis Activity

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You will act as a business analyst: upload three company reports into NotebookLM, ask it five questions, check its answers against the originals, and write a one-page briefing for management. This guide takes you through every click. Allow about 50 minutes.

Before you start

What is NotebookLM? It is a free Google tool where you upload your own documents and then chat with an AI that answers only from those documents. Every answer comes with small numbered links called citations that point to the exact passage it used.

Why use it? A normal chatbot answers from everything it has read online. NotebookLM answers from your files only, so you can check every claim. This is called *source-grounded AI*.

What you need

- A laptop or phone with internet and a Google account (a personal Gmail account is fine)
- The three practice PDF files from your teacher
- A Word or Google Docs file for your briefing

Key words

Word	Meaning
Notebook	A workspace in NotebookLM for one topic and its documents
Source	A document you upload into a notebook
Prompt	The question or instruction you type to the AI
Citation	A small number in the AI's answer that links to the passage in your source

Word	Meaning
Verify	Open the citation and check that the original really says what the AI claims
Information gap	Something you needed to know that the documents do not say

What you will hand in

1. One NotebookLM notebook with the sources and your five questions
2. One one-page management briefing

The case. Greenleaf Home Essentials is a fictional online home-goods retailer. Management wants to know how the business performed, why customers are unhappy, and what to do next. All figures are practice data.

Step 1: Get the three practice files

Your teacher will share three PDF files. Save them in one folder on your device so they are easy to find.

File	What it contains	Why you need it
Annual Business Report FY2025-26	Revenue, costs, profit, targets, sales by month and category	Shows how the business performed
Customer Feedback Report FY2025-26	Survey scores, complaints, delivery and support data, comments	Shows why customers are unhappy
Marketing Plan FY2026-27	Budget, campaigns, targets, competitors	Shows what management plans to do next

Check before moving on

- All three files open on your device and you can read them
- Each file shows the red Practice Data note on page 1
- You know where the folder is saved

Tip: Skim each file for two minutes first. It makes the answers easier to judge later.

Step 2: Open NotebookLM and create a notebook

1. Open your browser and go to **notebooklm.google.com**.
2. Sign in with your Google account if asked.
3. Click **Create new notebook** (the button may show a plus sign or the word New).
4. A window asking you to add sources may open straight away. Leave it open for Step 3.
5. Click the notebook title at the top (it may say Untitled notebook) and rename it to **Business Performance Analysis**.

What you should see: a sources area on the left, a chat box in the middle, and tools on the right. Menu names can change slightly when Google updates the app, so look for the closest match.

If you cannot sign in: your school account may block the tool. Use a personal Google account instead.

Step 3: Upload the sources and check them

1. Click **Add sources** (or the plus sign in the sources area).
2. Choose **Upload files**.
3. Select the Annual Business Report PDF. You can pick all three files at once by holding Ctrl (Windows) or Cmd (Mac).
4. Wait while NotebookLM processes the files. A small loading circle shows next to each file.
5. When the circles disappear, all three files should be listed under **Sources**.

Do not start asking questions until all three files have finished loading.

Check each source before you continue

- Are all three documents listed with the right names?
- Click one source: can you read its text on screen?
- Is every document about the same company and the same period?
- Does anything look outdated or contradict another document? Note it down. You will need it later.

Important: Never upload confidential company files or personal information about students or customers without permission. The practice files are safe to use.

Step 4: Understand the documents first (Prompt 1)

Before asking for findings, find out what is actually inside the files. Click the chat box at the bottom of the notebook, paste the prompt below, and press Enter.

> **Prompt 1.** Using only the documents in this notebook, explain the purpose of each document. Summarize the main topics, important business metrics, and any limitations in the information provided. Clearly distinguish information stated in the documents from information that is missing.

How to read the answer

- Look for the small numbers (citations) after each sentence. Hover over one to preview the passage it comes from.
- Write a two-line summary of each document in your own words.
- Note anything the AI says is missing. These are your first information gaps.

You should find, for example: the Annual Report covers money and sales, the Feedback Report covers complaints and satisfaction, and the Marketing Plan covers budget and campaigns. Check this against the real files and do not assume it.

What you learn: you cannot judge an answer until you know what information exists.

Step 5: Ask the five business questions

Paste the prompts one at a time, in this order. Wait for each answer, read it, and save the useful parts in your notes before moving to the next.

Question 1: Summarize the business

> Summarize the five most important findings across the business documents. Include relevant figures where available and cite the sources that support each finding.

Purpose: get the big picture. Expect points on falling revenue, rising costs, lower satisfaction and delivery problems.

Question 2: Business performance

> What do the documents say about revenue, expenses, sales performance, and business targets? Compare periods only where comparable data is available. Cite the evidence and state when a comparison cannot be made.

Purpose: understand the numbers. Write down revenue, profit or loss, and the gap to target.

Question 3: Customer problems

> Analyze the customer feedback report. Identify the most frequently mentioned customer problems, provide counts or percentages only when the data supports them, and cite the relevant evidence. If the report does not provide enough information to rank the problems, explain why.

Purpose: find what customers complain about most, with numbers.

Question 4: Business risks

> Identify the three most important business risks supported by these documents. For each risk, explain the evidence, possible business impact, and what additional information management would need before acting.

Purpose: spot problems that could hurt future performance.

Question 5: Recommend actions

> Based only on the evidence in the documents, recommend three practical actions management could consider. For each action, state which finding supports it, the expected benefit, and any assumption or missing information. Do not present assumptions as established facts.

Purpose: turn the analysis into next steps.

Tips for this step

- Paste the whole prompt exactly as written, including the words using only the documents.
- If an answer is too long or unclear, ask a follow-up such as: Explain that in simpler words and cite the source.
- Do not copy every answer blindly. The next step is to test them.

- Keep a notes file with the question number, the key points and the citation numbers.

Step 6: Verify at least three answers using citations

AI can sound confident and still be wrong. A citation lets you check. It is not proof that the answer is correct.

Do this for each of three claims

1. **Choose a claim** from the AI's answers, one with a number or a clear statement.
2. **Click the citation number** after that sentence. NotebookLM jumps to the passage in your source.
3. **Read the original passage** yourself. Do not rely on the AI's summary.
4. **Compare:** do the numbers, dates, category and wording match what the AI said?
5. **Record the result** as Supported, Partly supported, Unsupported or Unclear.

Worked example (your answers may differ)

AI claim	Source checked	What the source says	Result
Delivery delays are the biggest complaint, about 40 percent	Customer Feedback Report, section 4	312 of 780 complaints are delivery delays, which is 40 percent	Supported
Revenue fell because of weak consumer demand	Annual Report, chairman's message	Management says this, but the report gives no evidence for it	Partly supported

The second example shows an important skill. The AI repeated what a document said, but the document itself offered no proof. Say so in your briefing.

Your verification table. Copy this into your notes and fill it in.

AI claim	Source checked (document and section)	Result
Claim 1		
Claim 2		
Claim 3		

Look out for these

- Numbers that do not match the source, or a percentage the AI calculated itself
- A claim that blends two documents without saying so
- Advice presented as fact
- Two documents that disagree. This is a strong finding, so write it down.

If the source contradicts the AI, correct the claim or leave it out of your briefing.

Step 7: Write the one-page management briefing

Open Google Docs or Word and write a briefing a busy manager can read in two minutes. Use your verified findings, not a paste of the whole AI chat. Stay within one page.

Template: use these six headings

Heading	What to write	Length
1. Business objective	The problem or decision you investigated	1 to 2 sentences
2. Key findings	Three to five findings, each with a figure and its source document	3 to 5 bullets
3. Evidence and citations	The document and section that supports each important claim	One line per finding
4. Main business risks	Up to three risks and why they matter	3 bullets
5. Recommended actions	Three practical next steps, each linked to a finding	3 bullets
6. Limitations and information gaps	What is missing, uncertain or contradictory	2 to 4 bullets

Example of a good finding

- Weak: Customers are unhappy with delivery.
- Strong: Delivery delays are the largest complaint, 312 of 780 complaints (40 percent). Source: Customer Feedback Report, section 4.

Example of a good recommendation

- Weak: Improve delivery.

- Strong: Review the courier contract, because delivery time rose from 4.1 to 6.8 days after the July 2025 courier change. Assumption: the courier change caused the delay. More data on courier performance is needed.

Writing rules

- Every number needs a source in brackets.
- Use short sentences and plain words.
- Keep facts and opinions apart. Words like may and suggests mark opinions.
- Never present an assumption as a fact.
- Put your name, group name and date at the top.

Step 8: Present your findings in two minutes

Each group presents its briefing to the class. Use this order and keep to two minutes.

1. **The problem** you investigated (15 seconds)
2. **Two or three key findings** with figures (45 seconds)
3. **One citation you verified:** say what the AI claimed and what the source really said (30 seconds)
4. **One limitation or information gap** (15 seconds)
5. **Your main recommendation** (15 seconds)

Discussion question for the class: if NotebookLM gives a confident answer but the source does not support it, what should the analyst do?

Good answer: check the original document, correct or remove the unsupported claim, and say clearly when information is missing or uncertain.

Common problems and fixes

Problem	What to do
Cannot open NotebookLM	Try a personal Google account, a different browser, or a private window
A file will not upload	Check that it is a PDF under the size limit, then try again. Ask your teacher for a fresh copy

Problem	What to do
The AI says it cannot find the information	The documents may not contain it. This is a valid finding. Write it under information gaps
No citation numbers appear	Re-ask the question and add: cite the source for every point
The answer looks wrong	Open the citation and read the original. Correct the claim or leave it out
The answer is too long	Ask: summarize in five bullet points with citations
Two documents disagree	Do not choose one silently. Report the contradiction in your briefing
Your briefing is longer than one page	Cut to the strongest three findings and shorten each to one line

Final checklist and marking

Tick each item before you submit.

- [ ] Created a NotebookLM notebook named Business Performance Analysis
- [ ] Added at least two relevant business documents (three recommended)
- [ ] Asked the five business questions
- [ ] Verified at least three answers using citations
- [ ] Prepared a one-page management briefing
- [ ] Included recommendations and information gaps

How you will be marked (10 marks)

Criterion	Marks
Notebook setup and document selection	2
Quality and relevance of questions	2
Verification of three answers	3
Quality of briefing and recommendations	2
Identification of limitations	1

Criterion	Marks
Total	10

Marks are given for evidence and reasoning, not for a polished AI answer. If you find an unsupported claim and say so, that earns marks.

Remember: the aim is not to summarize documents with AI. It is to turn documents into useful insights, check the evidence, admit what is uncertain, and make better-informed recommendations.